Overview on Primates

Study notes: classification, key traits and the species I've seen

First split: wet nose vs dry nose

Wet-nosed STREPSIRRHINES

- Moist nose
- Rely on their sense of smell

e.g. lemurs, lorises and galagos

Dry-nosed HAPLORHINES

- Dry nose
- Rely on their sense of sight

e.g. tarsiers, monkeys and apes

Patterns to remember

- All apes have no tail.
- Most monkeys and lemurs have tails.
- New World monkeys have flat noses with sideways nostrils; Old World monkeys have narrow, downward-facing nostrils.

Classification

1 · Wet-nosed STREPSIRRHINES

Lemurs

◦ Madagascar only

- Very short fertile window: about a day, or even less in some species
- Most have one baby; ruffed lemurs are the exception, with twins or triplets
- Most lemur groups are female-dominated
- Many leaf-eaters barely drink, getting water from plants

Crowned sifaka · Black-and-white ruffed lemur · Blue-eyed black lemur · Ring-tailed lemur

Lorises & galagos

◦ Africa (galagos, pottos) & Asia (lorises)

- Nocturnal, with huge eyes
- Galagos (bushbabies) are fast jumpers; lorises are slow climbers
- The slow loris is the only venomous primate

Slow loris

2 · Dry-nosed HAPLORHINES

Tarsiers
- Southeast Asia

Tarsier

Anthropoids
Monkeys and apes, the primates that most resemble humans

New World monkeys PLATYRRHINI
- Central & South America ("New World" = the Americas)

Flat nose, nostrils face sideways

Emperor tamarin · Silvery marmoset

Old World CATARRHINI
- Africa & Asia

Old World monkeys
Barbary macaque: North Africa & Gibraltar. Males help care for infants, which is rare among monkeys.

Japanese macaque ("snow monkey"): the most northerly primate after humans.

Apes NO TAIL

Great apes
Bonobo · Gorilla · Chimpanzee · Orangutan · Humans

Lesser apes
Gibbons